

DIRECT & INDIRECT OBJECT PRONOUNS

Grammar Quick Guide

Once you can recognize a direct or indirect object, you can often replace it with a short pronoun. The pronoun you choose depends on **the type of object** and **who or what it refers to**.

1 Direct Object Pronouns

A **direct object pronoun (DOP)** replaces a direct object.

Compro el libro. → Lo compro.

I buy the book. → I buy it.

Veo a María. → La veo.

I see María. → I see her.

The direct object pronouns are:

Person	Singular	Plural
1st person	me — me	nos — us
2nd person	te — you	los / las — you
3rd person	lo / la — him, her, it	los / las — them

Choosing LO, LA, LOS or LAS

For third-person direct objects, the pronoun normally matches the **gender and number** of the noun it replaces:

el libro → lo la computadora → la

los libros → los las llaves → las

Compro el libro. → Lo compro.

Necesito la computadora. → La necesito.

Busco los documentos. → Los busco.

Tengo las llaves. → Las tengo.

The same pronouns can replace people:

Veo a Carlos. → Lo veo.
Veo a Ana. → La veo.
Invito a Carlos y Pedro. → Los invito.
Invito a Ana y Laura. → Las invito.

The **personal a** disappears because the entire direct object is replaced:

Veo a María. → La veo.

2 Indirect Object Pronouns

An **indirect object pronoun (IOP)** replaces or refers to an indirect object.

Doy el libro a María. → Le doy el libro.
I give the book to María. → I give her the book.

The indirect object pronouns are:

Person	Singular	Plural
1st person	me — to/for me	nos — to/for us
2nd person	te — to/for you	les — to/for you
3rd person	le — to/for him, her, you	les — to/for them, you

Notice an important difference:

DIRECT: lo / la / los / las

INDIRECT: le / les

Compare:

Veo a María. → La veo.
María = direct object

Doy el libro a María. → Le doy el libro.
María = indirect object

The person is the same. The pronoun changes because **the grammatical role changes**.

3 ME, TE and NOS Can Be Both

Some object pronouns have the same form whether they are direct or indirect:

Pronoun	Direct	Indirect
me	Me ve.	Me da el libro.
te	Te ayudo.	Te explico el problema.
nos	Nos invita.	Nos muestra la casa.

So **me**, **te**, and **nos** do not tell you by themselves whether the object is direct or indirect. Look at the verb and its pattern.

Compare:

Ana me ve.
ver a alguien → **me = direct**

Ana me muestra una foto.
mostrar algo a alguien → **me = indirect**

This is why recognizing the patterns from the previous guide is useful.

4 Basic Placement: Before a Conjugated Verb

For now, use one basic placement rule:

Object pronoun + conjugated verb

Lo compro. La conozco. Los necesito.
Le escribo. Les explico el problema. Te ayudo.

This works with different conjugated forms:

La veo todos los días.
La vi ayer.
La voy a ver mañana.

At this stage, focus on recognizing and choosing the correct pronoun. Object pronouns have additional placement options with infinitives, gerunds, and commands. Those patterns are covered in the next guide.

5 Keep the Indirect Object Pronoun

In Spanish, the indirect object pronoun is **normally used even when the indirect object is also explicitly mentioned**:

Le doy el libro a María.
Le explico el problema a Carlos.
Les envío un mensaje a mis padres.

So a very common pattern is:

LE / LES + verb + ... + A + PERSON

Both parts refer to the same indirect object.

The explicit **a + person** identifies or clarifies who **le/les** refers to:

Le doy el libro a María.
Le doy el libro a Carlos.

Le alone does not tell us whether the person is María, Carlos, or someone else.

Although Spanish can omit the pronoun in some contexts, **using it is the normal pattern learners should acquire**.

* With *a mí, a ti, a él, a ella...*

When the indirect object is expressed with **a + pronoun**, keep the indirect object pronoun:

Me dio el libro a mí.
Te explicó el problema a ti.
Le di el libro a ella.
Les envié el mensaje a ellos.

Don't use **a mí, a ti, a él, a ella, a nosotros, a ellos**, etc. by itself:

~~Di el libro a ella.~~
Le di el libro a ella. ✓

The **a + pronoun** form can clarify or emphasize the person, but it does not replace **me, te, le, nos, or les**.

6 Compare Direct and Indirect Pronouns

Original sentence	Object	Pronoun	New sentence
Compro el libro .	Direct	lo	Lo compro.
Veo a María .	Direct	la	La veo.
Invito a mis amigos .	Direct	los	Los invito.
Doy el libro a María .	Indirect	le	Le doy el libro.
Explico el problema a Carlos .	Indirect	le	Le explico el problema.
Envío un mensaje a mis padres .	Indirect	les	Les envío un mensaje.

Notice the contrast:

Veo a María. → La veo.

Muestro la foto a María. → Le muestro la foto.

Invito a Carlos. → Lo invito.

Envío una invitación a Carlos. → Le envío una invitación.

The person does not determine the pronoun. **The person's role in the sentence does.**

7 How to Choose the Pronoun

- 1. Identify the object first.** Is it direct or indirect? Don't choose the pronoun before you know its role.
- 2. Identify who or what the object refers to.** Is it me, you, him, her, us, them, or a thing?

3. Choose the pronoun.

For a direct object:

me · te · lo/la · nos · los/las

For an indirect object:

me · te · le · nos · les

4. With a conjugated verb, put the pronoun before the verb.

Veo a Ana. → La veo.
Escribo a Ana. → Le escribo.

5. Remember that indirect objects are often also explicitly mentioned.

Le escribo a Ana.
Les explico el problema a mis estudiantes.

Quick Reference

	Singular	Plural
Direct Object	me · te · lo / la	nos · los / las
Indirect Object	me · te · le	nos · les

The key contrast

DIRECT

Veo a Ana.
→ La veo.

INDIRECT

Muestro la foto a Ana.
→ Le muestro la foto.

First identify the **role**. Then choose the **pronoun**.

Next: Placement & Combinations

This guide uses the basic pattern **pronoun + conjugated verb**. The next guide covers what happens with **infinitives, gerunds, commands, two object pronouns together, and le/les → se**.